seriously argues that they must be observed to the letter today. (Indeed, it is debatable whether they were strictly followed even in the times it which they were propounded.) In fact, the Smritis were not all internally consistent:

> *A profusion of arguments! The Smritis differ among themselves.*
> *No one's opinion is final or conclusive.*
> *The essence of dharma is hidden and elusive.*
> *The right path is the path followed by great men.*
>
> — *Yaksha Prashna*, Sloka 114[12]

The *Itihasas*, the epics, respond to the human need for instruction through story: the profound philosophical enquiries of the Srutis and the *Smritis* are more easily digested by the common people in the form of parables and epic narratives (which in turn easily lend themselves to theatrical form, dance and music, all the better to communicate their message to the masses). *Itihasa* literally means 'the way it was' and many take the epics literally, though they have been embroidered with mystical and fantastic elements, and it is quite probable that divinity was ascribed to their principal personages only in later retellings. Their principal purpose remains to impart the values of the *Dharmashastras* in story form. The *Ramayana* tells the story of a kingly figure, Rama, who upholds both his personal *dharma* and his raja *dharma*: in the earliest versions he was not portrayed as a god, but as an ideal man devoted to upholding truth. Indeed there is impressive evidence for the historicity of Rama in Valmiki's text, which is replete with astonishingly accurate geographical, botanical and zoological details about his journey from Ayodhya to Lanka and back.[13] He makes enormous sacrifices in his personal life, including giving up his beloved wife, in order to fulfil his *dharma*. The *Mahabharata* was told and retold, with countless interpolations and additions, till about 400 CE; it incorporates the classic poem, the Bhagavad Gita, the Song of the Lord, which distils the essence of the *Upanishad*s and is to many Hindus the core religious text of their faith.

The two great Hindu epics, the *Ramayana* and the *Mahabharata*, tell stirring stories accompanied by digressive meditations on values, morals and principles. They are polycentric and fundamental texts about such